
doc_id: INFOSEC
title: Information Security & Devices
version: "4.0"
effective_date: "2026-01-01"
owner: Information Security
audience: all

Information Security & Devices

1. Scope

This policy binds everyone who holds a Westline account, touches a newsroom system, handles source material, or uses any device to make Westline work. Staff, contractors and creator partners are all covered, without exception, because an attacker does not care how you are engaged. See HANDBOOK section 2.

Two obligations in this document are absolute and are worth stating at the front: the virtual private network requirement on untrusted networks in section 4, and the prohibition on carrying source material across an international border in section 6.

2. Accounts and devices

2.1 Identity

Every person has one Westline identity, provisioned under ONBOARD section 4 and revoked under ONBOARD section 6.1. Accounts are never shared, never transferred, and never used by anyone other than the person they were issued to, including a colleague covering your shift.

2.2 Passwords

Passwords for Westline systems are unique, are at least sixteen characters, and are stored only in the approved password manager. Reusing a Westline password anywhere else, or storing one in a note, a spreadsheet, a browser profile on an unmanaged machine, or a message to yourself, is a breach.

2.3 Multi-factor authentication

Multi-factor authentication is mandatory on every Westline account and is enrolled before first sign-in. Hardware keys and authenticator applications are approved. Text-message codes are permitted only where no other method is available on that system, because they are defeated by number porting.

Approving a multi-factor prompt you did not initiate is a reportable incident under section 7, not an annoyance to dismiss. Attackers rely on people tapping approve to make the buzzing stop.

2.4 Managed devices

Staff use Westline-issued laptops for Westline work. Those devices are encrypted at rest, are enrolled in device management, receive security updates automatically, and lock after five minutes idle. Deferring an operating-system update for more than seven days is a breach.

2.5 Contractor and creator partner devices

Contractors and creator partners work on their own equipment, which Westline does not manage. Minimum conditions apply to any device used for Westline work: full-disk encryption enabled, a screen lock, an operating system still receiving security updates, and no shared user account.

Where a contractor needs access to newsroom systems beyond assignment-scoped read access, Information Security issues a managed device or a hardened browser profile for the duration of the engagement rather than granting broad access to an unmanaged machine.

3. Source material and source protection

3.1 What counts as source material

Source identities, contact details, unpublished recordings, raw footage of identifiable people in sensitive situations, leaked documents, and any note that could identify a confidential source. If in doubt, treat material as source material.

3.2 Where it lives

Source material lives in the newsroom secure store, never on a personal cloud account, never in a personal messaging thread, and never on removable media outside a locked office. Access is granted per assignment and expires with the assignment.

3.3 Communicating with sources

Use the approved end-to-end encrypted messenger with disappearing messages enabled for sensitive contact. Do not use Westline email for a confidential source's identity. Do not store a source's real name alongside their material; use the pseudonym register held by the Editorial Standards desk.

3.4 Legal demands

Any subpoena, production order or law-enforcement request touching source material goes immediately to the Editorial Standards desk and to Legal, before any response is given, and before confirming that material exists. Do not answer, do not hand anything over, and do not delete anything. EDITORIAL section 7.3 governs and this section restates it because the demand usually arrives as a technical request rather than a legal one.

4. Networks

4.1 Untrusted networks and the virtual private network

Any network Westline does not operate is untrusted: café, hotel, airport, conference, venue press room, a source's home, and a mobile hotspot belonging to someone else.

The Westline virtual private network is mandatory before you sign in to any Westline system on an untrusted network. This is not advisory and it has no exceptions for a quick check, for a network with a password, or for a network the venue describes as secure. A password on a café network protects the café from freeloaders; it does not protect you from the person at the next table.

If the virtual private network will not connect, use a mobile hotspot from your own phone instead of connecting without it, and report the failure under section 7 so that it is fixed.

4.2 Home networks

A home network is a semi-trusted network. Change the router's default administrative password, keep its firmware current, and put smart-home devices on a separate guest network. The virtual private network is not mandatory at home, and is required the moment you leave it.

4.3 Public charging and peripherals

Do not connect a Westline device to an unknown charging port or an unknown cable. Carry your own charger and a power bank. Do not plug in a memory stick you were handed, including one handed to you by a source; take delivery of material through the secure store or, where that is impossible, hand the device to Information Security unopened.

5. Personal devices for content capture

5.1 When it is allowed

Capturing on a personal phone is normal and permitted for breaking news, for creator partner work, and wherever a phone is the right tool. The obligation is not to avoid it; the obligation is what happens next.

5.2 What must happen next

Transfer the material to the newsroom store, or for creator partners to the Creator Partnerships portal, within twenty-four hours. Then delete the local copy, including from the device's recently deleted album and from any automatic cloud backup. Automatic photo backup to a personal cloud account is the single most common way Westline material ends up outside Westline control.

5.3 What must not happen

Do not capture source material on a personal device where an alternative exists. Do not leave unpublished material on a personal device after the twenty-four hour window. Do not use a personal device with an automatic backup to a shared family account for any Westline work at all.

6. Crossing an international border

6.1 Notify before you travel

Notify Information Security at least five business days before travelling outside Canada with any device used for Westline work. This is a separate obligation from, and additional to, the People and Culture and Finance approval that REMOTE section 3.3 requires for any work outside Canada. Doing one does not do the other, and the security notification is required even for a holiday if you

are carrying a work device.

6.2 Travel devices

Information Security issues a clean travel laptop and, where the destination warrants it, a clean phone. Travel devices carry the minimum data needed for the trip, and nothing that is not needed at the destination. Your ordinary device stays home.

6.3 Source material does not cross borders

Source material is never carried across an international border, on any device, in any form, encrypted or not. There is no approval route for this and no exception for a device you believe is secure. A border officer in most jurisdictions may compel the surrender of a device and its passphrase, and encryption you cannot refuse to unlock protects nobody.

If you need material at the destination, retrieve it there over the virtual private network from the secure store, and remove the local copy before you travel home.

6.4 At the border

Power devices down fully before reaching the control point; disk encryption protects a powered-down device and does not protect a sleeping one. If a device is inspected, seized, or if you are asked to unlock one, comply if refusing puts you at risk, and report it to Information Security within two hours under section 7. A device that has left your sight at a border is treated as compromised, is not reconnected to any Westline network, and is returned to Information Security for reimaging.

7. Incidents

7.1 Report within two hours

Report to Information Security within two hours of becoming aware of any of the following: a lost or stolen device; a multi-factor prompt you did not initiate; a phishing message you interacted with; a suspected account compromise; source material sent to the wrong recipient; a device inspected or seized at a border; ransomware or unexpected encryption; and any occasion on which you signed in to a Westline system on an untrusted network without the virtual private network.

The two-hour clock runs from awareness, not from certainty, and it does not wait for your lead.

7.2 Reporting is not blame

Nobody at Westline has ever been disciplined for reporting a security incident promptly, including incidents they caused. The response to a phishing click is to contain it; the only version of this that ends badly is the one nobody reports for three days. Concealing an incident is a serious breach under CONDUCT section 8.

7.3 What to do first

Disconnect the device from the network but do not power it off unless instructed, because volatile evidence is lost on shutdown. Do not attempt to clean or repair it. Do not warn the sender of a phishing message. Write down what happened and when while you still remember it.

7.4 After an incident

Information Security investigates and reports material incidents to the affected people and, where personal information was exposed, to the relevant privacy commissioner within the statutory period. Reviews are about the conditions that allowed the incident, and are published to the security register with names removed.

8. Data handling and retention

8.1 Classification

Public means published or intended for publication. Internal means ordinary Westline business. Confidential means personnel, benefits, financial and commercial material. Restricted means source material and anything under section 3. Handling requirements rise with the classification, and Restricted material never leaves the secure store.

8.2 Retention

Published material is retained indefinitely. Raw footage is retained for twenty-four months unless an editorial hold applies. Source material is retained only while the story requires it, and is then destroyed on the Editorial Standards desk's instruction. Personnel and benefits records follow the statutory retention period for the province of employment.

8.3 Deleting on request

Deletion requests from members of the public are handled by Legal, never by the individual holding the material, and never by deleting something first and asking afterwards.

9. Quick reference

9.1 Clocks

Report any incident in section 7.1 to Information Security within two hours of becoming aware. Notify Information Security at least five business days before travelling outside Canada with a work device. Transfer material captured on a personal device to the newsroom store within twenty-four hours, then delete the local copy including the automatic cloud backup. Apply an operating system security update within seven days.

9.2 Absolutes

There are four rules in this document with no exception path, and it is worth knowing which they are.

The virtual private network is mandatory on any untrusted network before signing in to any Westline system, per section 4.1. Source material never crosses an international border in any form, encrypted or not, per section 6.3. Westline accounts are never shared with anyone, per section 2.1. Multi-factor authentication is enrolled on every account before first sign-in, per section 2.3.

9.3 By class

Staff work on Westline-issued managed devices under section 2.4. Contractors and creator partners work on their own equipment and must meet the minimum conditions in section 2.5: full-disk

encryption, a screen lock, an operating system still receiving security updates, and no shared user account. Every other obligation in this document applies identically across all three classes, because an attacker does not care how someone is engaged.

10. Worked examples

10.1 Filing from a hotel

A producer wants to check the newsroom system from a hotel room. The hotel network is untrusted under section 4.1 regardless of the password on the card, so the virtual private network goes on first. If it will not connect, the correct action is a personal mobile hotspot, not a quick check without it, and the connection failure is reported under section 7.1 so that it gets fixed.

10.2 A phishing click

A reporter enters credentials on a page reached from an email, realises within a minute, and changes the password. That is not the end of it. It is a reportable incident under section 7.1 and the clock is two hours from awareness, not from certainty. Disconnect the device from the network, do not power it off, do not warn the sender, and write down what happened while it is fresh, per section 7.3.

Nobody at Westline has been disciplined for reporting an incident promptly, including one they caused. Concealing it is a serious breach under CONDUCT section 8. The version of this that ends badly is the one nobody reports for three days.

10.3 A multi-factor prompt at three in the morning

Approving a prompt you did not initiate is a reportable incident, not an annoyance to dismiss, per section 2.3. Deny it, then report it within two hours. Attackers rely on people tapping approve to make the buzzing stop, and a denied prompt at an odd hour usually means a password is already compromised.

10.4 A memory stick from a source

Do not plug it in, per section 4.3. Take delivery of the material through the secure store, or where that is impossible, hand the device to Information Security unopened. This holds even where the source is known and trusted, because the source may not know what is on it.

10.5 Shooting on a personal phone

Permitted and normal under section 5.1. What matters is the next twenty-four hours: transfer to the newsroom store or, for creator partners, the Creator Partnerships portal, then delete the local copy including from the recently deleted album and from the automatic cloud backup, per section 5.2. Automatic photo backup to a personal cloud account is the single most common way Westline material leaves Westline control, and a device backing up to a shared family account must not be used for Westline work at all.

10.6 Six weeks working from Lisbon

Three separate obligations run in parallel and doing one does not do the others.

REMOTE section 3.3 requires People and Culture and Finance approval before departure, six weeks ahead, for any work outside Canada regardless of duration. This document requires a separate notification to Information Security at least five business days before travelling with a work device, per section 6.1, and that notification applies even to a holiday if a work device is coming along. A travel device is issued under section 6.2 and the ordinary device stays home.

Under section 6.3 no source material travels, on any device, in any form. Material needed at the destination is retrieved there over the virtual private network from the secure store, and the local copy is removed before travelling home.

At the control point, devices are powered down fully rather than left asleep, per section 6.4.

10.7 A device inspected at a border

Comply if refusing puts you at risk. Report it to Information Security within two hours under section 7.1. A device that has left your sight at a border is treated as compromised: it is not reconnected to any Westline network and it goes back to Information Security for reimaging, per section 6.4.

10.8 A production order arriving by email

It usually arrives looking like a technical request rather than a legal one, which is why section 3.4 exists. It goes immediately to the Editorial Standards desk and to Legal, before any response is given, and before confirming that material exists. Do not answer, do not hand anything over, and do not delete anything. EDITORIAL section 7.3 governs and this section restates it.